

Topic 2.2 - Codes of conduct, and the four people a teacher owes them to

A real classroom situation

Mr Aslam teaches Class 9 biology. A pupil, Bilal, fails the term examination badly. Four things happen in the following week.

Bilal asks Mr Aslam privately whether he is simply not capable of biology. Mr Aslam, tired, says he should "think about a different subject". Bilal's mother arrives and asks what happened; Mr Aslam tells her Bilal does not work, which is not quite true. The head of department asks for the mark sheet; Mr Aslam has not finished marking and copies forward last term's marks for the six scripts he has not reached. In the staff room, he mentions to a colleague that Bilal's family "are not educated people".

Four separate failures, to four different parties, arising from one bad week. No single one of them would be described as a scandal. Together they are a fair picture of what it looks like when a teacher's obligations quietly stop being met.

Explanation

A code of ethical conduct is a written statement of what a profession's members owe and to whom. Codes differ in wording, but almost all of them organise the obligation by the party it is owed to. That organisation is the useful part, because it lets you check your practice against four questions rather than one vague one.

Ethical conduct toward students

The first and heaviest domain. At minimum a code requires that a teacher protects pupils from harm, including harm the teacher causes; treats them without discrimination on grounds of sex, ethnicity, religion, disability or family background; respects their dignity in public and in private; and does not exploit the relationship for personal advantage, financial or otherwise.

Mr Aslam's answer to Bilal breaches this domain. A pupil asked a question about his own capacity at a moment of maximum vulnerability, and received a verdict. The verdict may even have been accurate about the examination. It was not a defensible thing to hand a fifteen-year-old as a settled fact about himself.

Note what makes this hard to see: nothing was done *to* Bilal. A sentence was said. Breaches in this domain are usually made of ordinary speech.

Ethical conduct in practice and performance

The second domain is about competence rather than kindness, and it is the one trainee teachers most often leave out of their picture of ethics.

It requires that you are prepared, that you teach the curriculum you are employed to teach, that you keep your subject knowledge current, and that your assessment is honest. Assessment honesty matters more than it looks. A mark is a public claim about a pupil that others will rely on.

Mr Aslam copying forward last term's marks is the clearest breach in the vignette, and the one most likely to be defended as a small administrative shortcut. It is not. Six pupils now carry a mark that describes work nobody read. If one of them is placed in a lower set on that basis, the harm is real and untraceable.

Being under-prepared is the same category of failure, more slowly. A teacher who has not prepared is charging a class the cost of their own time.

Ethical conduct toward parents and the community

The third domain covers honesty with parents, respect for the family's circumstances, and the teacher's standing in the community they serve.

It requires accurate reporting about a child, not a comfortable version or a punitive one. It requires that difficult information is delivered in a way a parent can act on. And it requires that a family's poverty, language, caste or lack of schooling never becomes a reason to treat the child as less entitled to your effort.

Mr Aslam told Bilal's mother that Bilal does not work. It was near enough to true to feel honest and far enough from true to be useless: it gave her nothing to act on and told her that the problem was her son's character. A parent who cannot read the textbook can still change what happens at home, if you tell her something specific.

Ethical conduct toward colleagues and the profession

The fourth domain is the one most easily dismissed as workplace politeness. It is not. It covers fair dealing with colleagues, not undermining them in front of pupils, contributing to shared work rather than free-riding on it, and declining to damage the profession's standing.

Mr Aslam's staff-room remark about Bilal's family belongs here and in the first domain at once. A remark like that circulates. Within a term, several teachers hold a view of Bilal formed from a sentence nobody examined, and the pupil is taught by all of them.

The professional standing point is the part trainees underestimate. Teaching's claim to be treated as a profession rests on public confidence, and that confidence is collective. One teacher who sells examination papers lowers the standing of every teacher in the province.

Local and international codes, and what a written code cannot settle

Codes exist at several levels, and they are not rivals.

At the international level, UNESCO and the International Task Force on Teachers set out a global framework of professional teaching standards, which gives a reference point independent of any one employer. At the national level in

Pakistan, the *National Professional Standards for Teachers* (2009) set out the standards teacher education and practice are accredited against; the National Accreditation Council for Teacher Education accredits programmes against that document rather than publishing a separate code of ethics. Below both, individual schools and systems hold their own service rules.

Reading them together is the skill. An international framework says what the profession everywhere aspires to. A national document says what this country has committed to and can hold you to. A school's rules say what happens on Monday. When they conflict, the conflict itself is information: it usually marks a place where local practice has drifted from what the profession claims.

Now the limitation, which matters as much as the content. **A code cannot settle every case, and it is not trying to.** Three reasons:

- Codes are general and situations are particular. "Respect pupil dignity" does not tell you whether to correct a pupil's error in front of the class.
- Codes conflict with themselves. Honesty toward a parent and protection of a pupil's confidence can point in opposite directions, as Topic 2.4 shows in detail.
- Codes are silent on almost everything. Miss Rabia in Topic 2.1 breached no code.

This is why the rest of the unit is about models for deciding rather than more rules to follow. A code tells you what is settled. Judgement is what the profession asks of you everywhere else, and the nested circles in the figure above are drawn with gaps for exactly that reason.

Activity: Four domains, one incident

Work in groups of four. Take the Mr Aslam vignette at the top of this topic. Assign one domain to each group member: students; practice and performance; parents and community; colleagues.

Each person writes, alone and in five minutes, what their domain required Mr Aslam to do differently in that week. Then read them aloud in turn.

Two questions for the group afterwards. First: did any two of your prescriptions conflict? Second: which domain would have been noticed if Mr Aslam had breached it alone? Spend ten minutes on the second question, because the answer explains why the quietest failures persist.

Allow 25 minutes in total.

Check your understanding

1. Name the four domains a code of ethical conduct typically organises obligations by. (*Remember*)
2. Explain why copying forward unmarked scripts is an ethical failure and not merely an administrative one. (*Understand*)
3. A teacher says a code of conduct is pointless because "it cannot cover every situation". Explain what is right in that observation and why the conclusion does not follow. (*Analyze*)
4. Classify each of Mr Aslam's four failures by domain, and say for each who would notice first. (*Apply*)
5. Give one example of information about a pupil that is accurate but useless to a parent, and rewrite it so the parent can act on it. (*Apply*)

Summary

A code of ethical conduct states what a teacher owes and to whom, and it organises that obligation by party: students, one's own practice and performance, parents and the community, and colleagues and the profession. Breaches in the first domain are usually made of ordinary speech; breaches in the second are usually defended as shortcuts; breaches in the third often take the form of accurate but unusable information; breaches in the fourth spread.

Codes exist at international, national and school level, and reading them together is a professional skill. But a code is a summary of settled judgement, not a decision procedure. It is general where situations are particular, it conflicts with itself, and it is silent on most of what a teacher actually does.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can name the four domains of conduct a code addresses and give an example breach in each.
- ☐ I can explain why assessment honesty is an ethical obligation and not an administrative one.
- ☐ I can describe how the international framework, the national standards and a school's own rules relate to one another.
- ☐ I can state three reasons a written code cannot settle every case.
- ☐ I can rewrite unusable feedback to a parent into something the parent can act on.

Try this at your practicum school

Ask to see whatever written code, service rules or staff handbook your practicum school operates under. Many schools have something, even if it is only a page.

Read it with the four domains in front of you. Which domains does it cover in detail? Which does it barely mention? Write half a page on what the document's emphasis tells you about what the school has had trouble with in the past, and note one situation you have witnessed on placement that the document does not reach.

If the school has no written code at all, that is itself the finding. Write about what fills the gap instead.

Summative task

Write 400 to 450 words.

Using the Mr Aslam vignette, take the two failures you judge most serious and the one you judge least serious. Justify the ranking.

Your answer must name the domain each failure belongs to, explain the harm in each case including who bears it and when, and defend your judgement about the least serious one against the strongest objection you can construct.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Domain identification (Understand)	Correctly assigns each chosen failure to its domain and shows why it belongs there
Account of harm (Apply)	Names who is harmed, how, and over what time scale, rather than asserting seriousness
Justified ranking (Evaluate)	Defends the ranking with a stated criterion of seriousness, and answers the strongest objection to the least-serious judgement rather than a weak one
Use of sources	Refers accurately to at least one code or standard rather than to ethics in general

Further reading

- UNESCO / International Task Force on Teachers (2019). *Global framework of professional teaching standards*.
<https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000372167>
- Government of Pakistan, Ministry of Education (2009). *National Professional Standards for Teachers in Pakistan*. The standards Pakistani teacher education is accredited against.
- Carr, D. (2000). *Professionalism and ethics in teaching*. Routledge.

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